

Problem Statement: Conversational Commerce Agents for Every Merchant

Background

Today, online shopping is fragmented. Consumers browse, compare, decide, and pay across multiple interfaces and steps. Meanwhile, most merchants—especially SMEs—lack the resources to build intelligent, AI-driven commerce experiences with seamless payments.

With the rise of AI agents, there is an opportunity to transform commerce into a **single conversational journey** where users can discover products, make decisions, and complete payments—all in one interaction.

Visa's payment infrastructure enables secure, trusted transactions globally. The challenge is to make this real, for consumers to discover products, from a seller or a category of sellers, be able to complete the process starting from conversation to payment. This will allow **embedding this capability into intelligent, merchant-facing AI agents from day one**.

Challenge

How might we enable merchants of any size to deploy pre-built, category-trained AI commerce agents on their platforms, allowing customers to discover, decide, and pay through a single conversation—powered by Visa's payment stack?

Expected Submissions

Design and prototype a **plug-and-play conversational commerce solution** that includes:

1. **AI Agent Layer**
 - A chatbot or voice assistant trained for a specific category (e.g., food ordering, fashion, electronics, travel bookings etc.)
 - Handles product discovery, recommendations, comparison and decision to buy
1. **Merchant Integration**
 - A simple way for merchants to become ready for agents to shop (e.g., upload catalog, connect APIs, no-code/low-code setup)
 - Customizable for different merchant types / sizes (SMEs vs large retailers)
2. **Seamless Payment Flow**

- Integrate a mock or simulated Visa payment flow
 - Ensure frictionless checkout within the conversation (no redirects)
 - 3. **Trust, Consent & Transparency**
 - Show how users authorize agent-driven actions (e.g., confirming purchases)
 - Include safeguards like transaction previews, identity verification, confirmation before agent transacts
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Expected Output

- A working prototype (web/app/chat interface)
 - Demo/video of end-to-end flow: **discover** → **decide** → **pay**
 - Brief explanation of:
 - Architecture (AI + payments integration)
 - Merchant onboarding flow
 - How trust and security are handled
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Judging rubrics

- **Innovation:** Novelty of the agentic commerce experience
 - **User Experience:** Simplicity and intuitiveness of the conversation flow
 - **Technical Feasibility:** Realistic integration of AI + payment concepts
 - **Scalability:** Applicability across merchants of different sizes
 - **Trust & Safety:** Clear handling of consent, security, and transparency
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Why This Matters

This challenge sits at the intersection of **AI, fintech, and commerce infrastructure**—giving students the chance to design the future of how people buy and sell, while exploring real-world systems like payments, trust, and intelligent agents. It aligns strongly with Visa’s innovation focus on **agentic commerce and trusted AI payments**